OTT TITANS · RIDDLE VAULT

THE MISSING DOLLAR

WHERE DID IT GO?

THE CASE IN ONE LINE
Thirty dollars go into a hotel. Twenty-nine can be found. Or can they?

CASE 05 · ONE RIDDLE · ONE ANSWER · NO SHORTCUTS

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THE CASE

Three friends check into a hotel. The room costs $30, so each pays $10 and they go upstairs.

Later the manager realises the room was on offer at $25. He sends the bellboy back with $5. On the way, the bellboy quietly keeps $2 for himself and returns $1 to each friend.

Now do the famous sum. Each friend has paid $9 — that is $27. The bellboy has $2. $27 + $2 = $29. The friends started with $30. A dollar is missing… apparently.

THE QUESTION

Where did the missing dollar go?

THREE HINTS

Open them one at a time. Stop the moment you have it — the last hint nearly gives it away.

HINT 1
Follow the money as two piles: what the friends no longer hold, and who is holding it now.

HINT 2
Ask a colder question: what is the $27 actually made of? List its ingredients.

HINT 3
In the famous sum, one amount is being counted on both sides of the ledger.

YOUR MOVE

Where did the missing dollar go?

Decide your answer now — say it out loud or write it in the comments — before you turn this page. No going back.

THE REVEAL

THE ANSWER

There is no missing dollar. The sum is rigged.

The $27 the friends paid is not separate from the bellboy's $2 — it contains it. Of the $27, $25 went to the hotel and $2 went to the bellboy. Adding the $2 again counts it twice.

The honest ledger: $25 (hotel) + $2 (bellboy) + $3 (handed back to the friends) = $30. Every dollar accounted for. Nothing vanished except a badly-built sum.

WHY IT WORKS

The trick is a category error dressed as arithmetic. $27 is money that left the friends' pockets. The bellboy's $2 is part of where it went — not an extra pile to add on top.

If you want to add something to $27, the only honest partner is the $3 the friends got back. Direction matters: money-out adds to money-out, never to money-held-by-someone-else.

THE TRAP, NAMED

The story marches you to the sum so smoothly that you perform it without asking whether the sum means anything. Addition is easy; bookkeeping is the skill.

MAKE THE VIDEO

This book is a production pack. The route from page to posted video:

1 · OPEN THE BOOK
The story, the question and the reveal in this book are your script beats, in order.

2 · GIVE IT TO THE AGENT
Paste the case into your AI agent (run it on Google Antigravity) and let it plan the shots from the beats.

3 · CONNECT GOOGLE FLOW
The agent builds the scenes as short clips in Flow. Keep the question on screen until the final seconds — the reveal is the last beat, never the first.

4 · EDIT + POST
Post with the question as the caption's first line and pin a comment asking for answers BEFORE the reveal. The debate in the comments is the engine.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

RIDDLE VAULT is the OTT Titans series of one-riddle books: one case per book, a verified answer, and the production route to turn it into a video. Every answer in this series is solved and checked before the book is made — if the logic has a hole, the riddle does not ship.

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More cases are waiting in the Vault — and a new riddle video lands every day on the 1 Minute Detective channels.

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